

Case study 1

As one of the first to enter the field of office automation, Sagatec Software, Inc. had built a reputation for designing high-quality and user-friendly database and accounting programs for business and industry. When they decided to enter the word-processing market, their engineers designed an effective, versatile, and powerful program that Sagatec felt sure would outperform any competitor.

To be sure that their new word-processing program was accurately documented, Sagatec asked the senior program designer to supervise writing the instruction manual. The result was a thorough, accurate and precise description of every detail of the program's operation.

When Sagatec began marketing its new word processor, cries for help flooded in from office workers who were so confused by the massive manual that they couldn't even find out how to get started. Then several business journals reviewed the program and judged it "too complicated" and "difficult to learn." After an impressive start, sales of the new word processing program plummeted.

Sagatec eventually put out a new, clearly written training guide that led new users step by step through introductory exercises and told them how to find commands quickly. But the rewrite cost Sagatec \$350,000, a year's lead in the market, and its reputation for producing easy-to-use business software.

Q1. What mistake did Sagatec make in documenting its new word-processing program, and how did this affect the product's success in the market?

Ans. Sagatec's main mistake was assigning the senior program designer—who had technical expertise but little knowledge of user needs—to write the manual. The documentation became overly detailed and technical, confusing ordinary users. As a result, customers found the software difficult to use, leading to poor reviews, decreased sales, and a damaged brand reputation.

Q2. What lessons about organizational communication and product documentation can businesses learn from Sagatec's experience?

Ans. Businesses can learn that product documentation must match the user's skill level and needs. Effective communication should simplify complex information. Involving technical writers or usability experts ensures clarity, better user experience, and market success, preventing costly rewrites and reputation loss.

Case Study 2

Joanne supervised 36 professionals in 6 city libraries. To cut the costs of unnecessary overtime, she issued this one-sentence memo to her staff:

When workloads increase to a level requiring hours in excess of an employee's regular duty assignment, and when such work is estimated to require a full shift of eight (8) hours or more on two (2) or more consecutive days, even though unscheduled days intervene, an employee's tour of duty shall be altered so as to include the hours when such work must be done, unless an adverse impact would result from such employee's absence from his previously scheduled assignment.

After the 36 copies were sent out, Joanne's office received 26 phone calls asking what the memo meant. What the 10 people who didn't call about the memo thought is uncertain. It took a week to clarify the new policy.

Q1. Discuss the problem and a two-point solution.

Ans. The problem was unclear, overly complex communication that confused employees. Joanne's memo used bureaucratic and lengthy phrasing.

Solution:

1. Use simple, direct language with short sentences.
2. Provide examples or bullet points to explain the new work policy clearly.